S. PAUL KAPUR: STRATEGIC PESSIMISM

The dominant school of proliferation pessimism argues that shortcomings within the organizations that manage nuclear weapons will make nuclear proliferation dangerous. For example, military services will adopt standard operating procedures that increase the likelihood of accident or will indulge officers' proclivity for offensive, destabilizing strategies. At first blush, this organizational argument appears to offer a fundamental challenge to the claims of proliferation optimism. Organizational pessimism expects proliferators to behave in ways that optimists do not predict, destabilizing rather than pacifying the international environment. Close examination reveals, however, that pessimist arguments in fact accept important optimistic beliefs. Specifically, pessimists do not challenge the optimists' claim that in a nuclear environment, strategic calculation should lead states to behave cautiously, thereby increasing international stability. Rather, pessimists show that organizational problems may short-circuit strategic policy formulation, preventing proliferators from adopting the cautious, stabilizing courses of action that they would otherwise embrace. Thus, in the leading pessimistic view, newly nuclear states will not behave dangerously because rational calculation or strategic policy formulation might encourage destabilizing behavior. Rather, dangerous behavior will occur because organizational pathologies interfere with strategic decision-making. Thus proliferation pessimism, in its dominant, organizational form, cedes important ground to the optimist camp. It does not challenge the optimists' fundamental claim that rational proliferators should be cautious proliferators

This is in no way to deny the significance of organizational pessimism's insights. Such pessimism points up important dangers that are likely to result from the spread of nuclear weapons. My claim is simply that despite its strengths the existing pessimist literature does not challenge proliferation optimism's core logic. In order to pose a more fundamental challenge to the optimists, a pessimistic approach would have to show that the acquisition of nuclear